

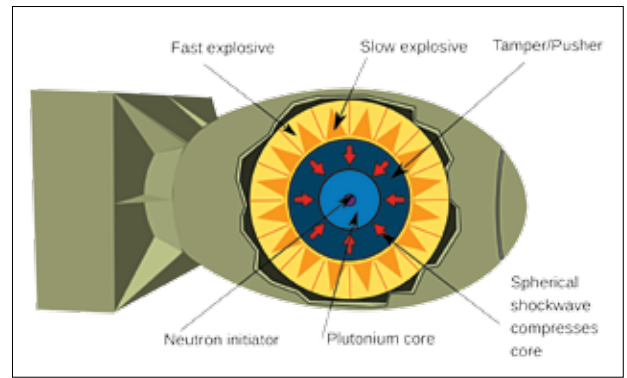
a whole new era of precision guided ammunitions, including surgical strikes.

Russia has taken the lead on developing smartbombs that actually work, through a system called as the SVP-24, which can even turn unguided traditional bombs into precision guided weapons that hit the most smallest target areas without causing any collateral damage. Where the Russian system fundamentally differs from the US guided munition kit (to precisely guide bombs to their targets) is that the American kit is attached to the iron bomb itself, while the Russian guidance system is attached to the bomber plane. The Russian SVP-24 constantly compares position of the target against its own moving aircraft via GLONASS satellite navigation. It also takes into consideration various parameters like pressure, humidity, speed, angle of attack to compute the exact time when the dumb bombs need to be released to bring their free fall trajectory right over the target. The much-costlier, \$25,000 per bomb guidance system installed on US bombs, however, have one key advantage over the Russian SVP-24, as it can course correct and re-route itself midair in case of incorrect trajectory at the time of launch.

**Railgun:** Yes, this is pretty much like the weapon we all used in Quake III Arena, but only much bigger in scale. For starters, railguns currently being developed by BAE Systems for the US Navy need to be mounted on ships – they aren't yet handheld (I know, right?). The railgun is smaller than a conventional cannon, but it doesn't need gunpowder or chemical-based

propellants to fire itself, depending solely on an electro-magnetic pulse that shoots a projectile at 7400 kmph or at Mach 6 speeds, taking just 10 milliseconds to attain that speed. This railgun can accurately hit a target over 100 nautical miles away. Unbelievable, right? But what's preventing railguns from being fitted onto every US Navy vessel in the near future is this – the 25 MW of power needed to fire these things (that's enough power to light up 19,000 homes) and the longevity of the railgun itself (it seems firing projectiles at such inhuman speeds can lead to the railgun getting shredded in no time). Can't have that, of course. But it seems BAE systems are close to solving both these problems, and once they do, it will be hard to see any water-borne enemy escaping from the crosshairs of this highly precise, extremely accurate railgun's firepower.

**Neutron bomb:** Like an Atom bomb, which destroys everything in a large area around the target, including living and nonliving structures within its blast radius, a neutron bomb is being hailed as the next big technological leap in global warfare. Why? Because a neutron bomb is essentially a weapon that produces large numbers of neutrons when it explodes (and not heat or blast wave), and it's, therefore, only harmful to living and breathing organ-



Neutron bomb is the thoughtful version of the atom bomb

isms, leaving property and structures relatively unscathed. Awesome, right? Because who wants to bomb enemy territory to smithereens, capture it and then spend lots of time and money rebuilding it all? Duh!

## BEYOND NUCLEAR

There's no doubt in our mind that the weapons of the future will be more efficient than nuclear weapons when it comes to unleashing deadly strikes against the enemy. According to various reports, research is underway among old superpowers and new on how to unleash hell in just the right measure. For instance, due to the help of certain meteorological weapons it's possible to alter the weather over a chosen terrain by changing the electric charge present in the air; create artificial rain, droughts or blizzards at the drop of a hat and wreak epic havoc. Tectonic weapons let you create artificial earthquakes with so much power that it can flatten entire towns and cities, and scheduling them will be increasingly easier in the future. Solar lasers directed by a killer satellite, which can virtually destroy any target on the earth's surface, aren't just a figment of someone's imagination as shown in James Bond's *Die Another Day*, but it's a very real possibility in the war theatre of our future. So is genetic poisoning as the most sure-shot way of destroying a large part of the population, based on a certain genetic code-triggered chemical weapon.

As inevitable as war seems in humanity's past, present and impending future, let's hope it isn't in our time that we get to witness such unfortunate days. 



Railgun, something that we have known only in novels and videogames, is now real